

LIFE & ARTS

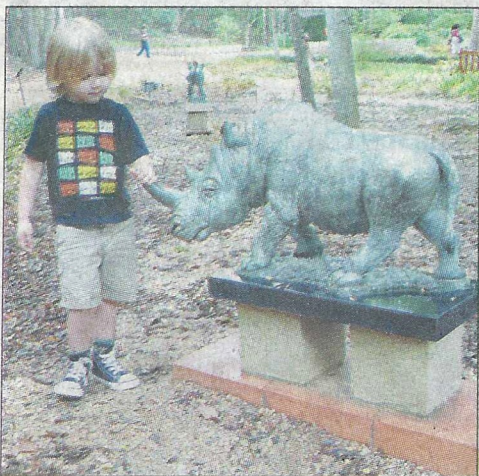
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PLANT SALE

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this weekend ■ Gardening, back page

EXPANDE

CAROLYN LINDELL RAISING AUSTIN



Carolyn Lindell FOR AMERICAN-STATESMAN

At Umlauf Sculpture Garden & Museum, Jack Cooper, 3, feels the horn of a rhinoceros sculpture after storytime at Sculpture Tales!

Storytime and sculptures at Umlauf museum

As well-intentioned parents know, a visit to a fine art museum often requires a lot of self-control for the kids, especially energetic kids who like to touch everything. Parents can get a headache just trying to watch over them.

That's why the Umlauf Sculpture Garden & Museum, right in the heart of Austin, is appealing for families. Children can skip along the shady pathways and even touch the glorious creations of renowned sculptor Charles Umlauf. On the six-acre grounds, kids also can wander across a wooden bridge, look out over a pond or hike up a short trail toward a waterfall.

About 50 sculptures, rotated periodically, are in the sculpture garden, said Sheila Fox, education and volunteer coordinator at the Umlauf. Many of the artworks are just the right height for kids, who seem to like the animal sculptures.

The Umlauf sculptures have been washed and waxed, so children can put their hands on them to feel the contours and surfaces.

"That thin layer of wax protects the bronze from salts and oils in exploring fingers," said Nelie Plourde, museum director. "It's so terrific because we can talk about the different textures, like how bristly the rhino is."

Of course, kids should not climb on the sculptures like they are at a playscape.

Charles Umlauf, who died in 1994, was an acclaimed sculptor who taught art at the University of Texas (Note: I happen to be friends with Umlauf's granddaughter). In 1985, Umlauf and his wife, Angeline, donated their house, studio and numerous artworks to the city. Private money was then raised to build the museum on neighboring city land.

Education is a strong focus at the Umlauf, which has programs for all types of groups and age levels. One program, "Sculpture Tales! A Mommy and Me Workshop," is a storytime for ages 3 to 5, on the second Wednesday morning of the month.

Since starting last spring, the 45-minute storytime has grown so popular that it might be expanded, Fox said. Reservations

See **RAISING**, G3

Umlauf Sculpture Garden & Museum

Where: 605 Robert E. Lee Road

Information: 445-5582, www.umlaufsculpture.org

Hours: 10 a.m. to 4:30 p.m. Wednesdays-Fridays, 1 p.m. to 4:30 p.m. Saturdays and Sundays. Closed Mondays and Tuesdays.

Admission: General \$3.50, seniors \$2.50; students \$1. Free to members and children younger than 6 years.

RAISING: At Umlauf, please touch the art; just don't climb on it

Continued from G1

are recommended, as it is limited to 15 participants. Cost is \$5 a child.

At a recent storytime one rainy morning, about a dozen fidgety preschoolers and their caregivers sat in a covered area (usually stories are told out in the garden). Storyteller Karen Hodges handed out shakers and castanets for some songs before launching into her story.

"I like to get them to participate so they don't get squirrely," she said.

Hodges said she tries to pick tales about one of the animals depicted in the garden. This particular day, Hodges told an old tale about a cake-eating rhino. Then the

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kids got some clay to make their own sculpture of a cake, with glue for icing.

"I like sprinkles," said Elliot Spellman-Burks, 3, as he decorated his masterpiece with glitter.

Then all the kids marched around in a cake parade, showing off their creations, before ambling down into the garden to touch and see the sculptures as the rain had subsided.

Katie Nott of North Cen-

tral Austin brought daughter Josie Blackwell, 3, for her first visit.

"We're always looking for activities, and that way she can learn about sculpture a little bit," Nott said.

For older kids (ages 7 to 11), the Umlauf also offers a monthly "Sculptor to Be" workshop, where children learn from an artist about sculpting and make a piece out of different materials. This program hasn't had a high turnout, and Fox said she might re-think it. (This workshop is offered at 1:30 p.m. today. Reservations required.)

Families also can ask about the Sculpture Safari, where kids earn reward stickers by locating various

sculptures pictured on big laminated pages.

One caution: The museum currently features an exhibit of fragile artwork by Damien Priour (through Jan. 3), including glass pieces on the floor. I didn't even let my son walk inside the door for that.

Otherwise, the garden is a calm place to visit (and admission prices are reasonable). My antsy 5-year-old even found it fun to stand perfectly still and pretend he was a statue, mimicking Umlauf's "St. Francis with Birds." What a miracle!

Just being outside in the serene garden makes it easier for parents to show their children some incredible art — without getting a headache.